

European Automobiles & Components

Volkswagen AG

Rating

Market-Perform

Price Target

 **VOW3.GR**

100.00 EUR



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Volkswagen: Na und? Some thoughts about the Future Plan

In German, the expression "Na und?" loosely translates as "So what?" or "What of it?" We can only hope that the devil really is in the detail, because the three pages press release entitled "Executive Board Presents Future Plan" that hit the wires at 9pm on 9 July was long on ideals but very short on specifics of how the plan would be executed. We do not expect the stock to react well to the details we have so far.

The plan in short VW stated that the model lineup will be gradually concentrated on the most attractive market segments and streamlined by up to 50% while the complexity of the range will be reduced by up to 75%. VW stated that it is extending its technology leadership, a claim that will likely raise eyebrows given the pace of innovation among its Chinese competitors. VW also stated that technology fields are being harmonized, group-wide synergies are being systematically realized, and parallel structures are being eliminated. Production capacities are being adjusted to the changed global market environment and the sharply intensified competition, targeting 9m vehicles per year (from 10m at present). In summary, CEO Oliver Blume stated that *"By 2030, we will make the Volkswagen Group the most attractive automotive company in the world – with iconic brands, inspiring products, leading technologies, robust financial results, reliable capital market performance and a team spirit in action. With our future plan, we are now entering the next phase of transformation."*

Where's the beef? Investors were already asking us, after the press release was published, "Where's the beef?" How will the 1m capacity reduction be achieved? On the morning of 9 July, Spiegel had run a story quoting unnamed supervisory board members with knowledge of the plans that VW would propose the phasing out of production at the VW plants in Zwickau and Emden in the next five years, while the commercial vehicle plant in Hanover would follow in 2032, and the Audi plant would then close in Neckarsulm in 2034. This would affect around 40,000 people employed directly at those plants. In the event, there was no mention of these plans in the Future Plan press release, although this did not prevent Work Council leader Daniella Cavallo calling for VW CEO Oliver Blume to take a stand with the workforce by Friday and to make an unequivocal statement about the rumors about the alleged board plans. *"The way the board of directors treats the workforce can no longer be surpassed in terms of disrespect. Oliver Blume now has a duty to at least limit this massive damage."* She warned that if the CEO does not comply with the request, there will be *"VW-wide and simultaneous extraordinary works meetings" after the summer break "to summon the board members there to the microphone."* Cavallo stressed that there should be no plant closures and that job cuts should only be voluntary and socially acceptable.

The usual dance or worse? There will undoubtedly be some who argue that this is all part of a well rehearsed dance between management and the workforce, that the union deep-down understands and accepts that German plants must close, but that each side must play its pre-ordained role while the closures go ahead after the spotlights have dimmed. However, there are others who will see this as a re-run of the 2024 negotiating round; then, it appeared that Oliver Blume had been tasked to demand the closure of a major plant in Germany and to extract significant wages and conditions concessions from the workforce. In the event, no large plant was shut down, the concessions achieved were smaller than those demanded, and the IG Metal union famously called the final December 2024 agreement *"The Miracle before Christmas."* After all the expectations, we expect a lot of "Na und?" from investors about Future Plan. **(Continued on Page Two)**

EXPECTED CHANGE TO CONSENSUS EARNINGS



(Continued from Page One)

Dashing hopes of a capital return from Everllence? One comment from the Future Plan will also require further clarification: a major part of the Bull case on VW this year has been that the proposed and now agreed sale of a majority stake in large diesel engine manufacturer Everllence might trigger a large one-time capital return. These expectations do not appear to correspond with the Future Plan comment that *“the transaction (€7.4bn cash inflow to VW group) simultaneously strengthens the Group’s balance sheet and expands the financial room to maneuver for the further strategic development of the Volkswagen Group”*.

BERNSTEIN TICKER TABLE

			9 Jul 2026		TTM	Adjusted EPS				Adjusted P/E (x)		
			Closing	Price	Rel.							
Ticker	Rating	Cur	Price	Target	Perf.	Cur	2025A	2026E	2027E	2025A	2026E	2027E
VOW3.GR (Volkswagen)	M	EUR	71.80	100.00	(39.2)%	EUR	13.35	17.76	21.48	5.4	4.0	3.3
EDME			1,593.15									

O - Outperform, M - Market-Perform, U - Underperform, NR - Not Rated, CS - Coverage Suspended

Source: Bloomberg, Bernstein estimates and analysis.

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We value Volkswagen using a SOTP methodology based on our 2026 estimates. We apply individual multiples for each of Volkswagen's divisions (core, progressive, luxury, etc.). For its financial services, we value it at a price to book ratio of 2.0x. We value its Chinese JVs on an EV/EBIT of 5.5x. We apply a 50% discount to reflect ongoing geopolitical uncertainty, intensified competition in China, and the nature of a conglomerate, along with the challenges we see in turning the group around. This yields a price target of €100.

RISKS**Volkswagen AG**

Downside risks to price target: 1) Slower uptake of BEVs in Europe puts VW group CO2 compliance targets at risk; 2) competition from cheap China-built BEVs in Europe. 3) Discovery of further content of cars sourced from sanctioned regions leads to penalties 4) China - the local market is extremely sensitive to moves in the stock market and government policy.

Upside risks to price target: 1) Management makes faster progress in cost-cutting measures, especially related to capex and R&D and to its European workforce. 2) VW decides to make further partial IPOs beyond P911 of its premium brands. 3) Current trade tensions between China and Europe de-escalate, reducing the likelihood of punitive tariffs on VW group products imported into China. 4) Management makes meaningful cuts at CARIAD, underscoring its commitment to moving much faster in vehicle software development.

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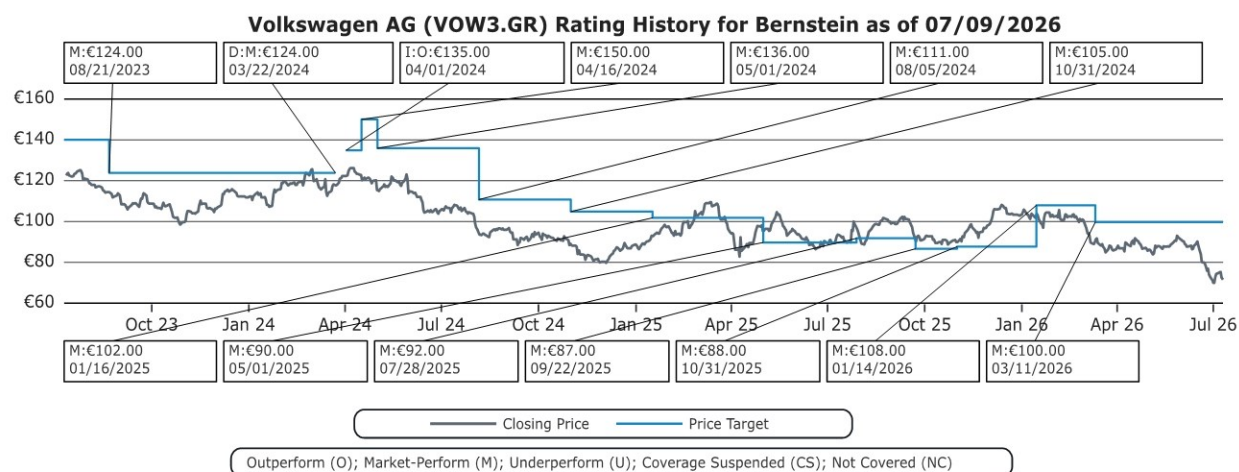
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Underperform	SELL	13.1%	13.6%

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